BOOKS ▼

IN THE **CORRIDORS** OF POWER

IN *I, WITNESS*, VETERAN JOURNALIST **SHAHID SIDDIQUI** RECOUNTS FIVE DECADES OF INDIAN POLITICS WITH CANDOUR

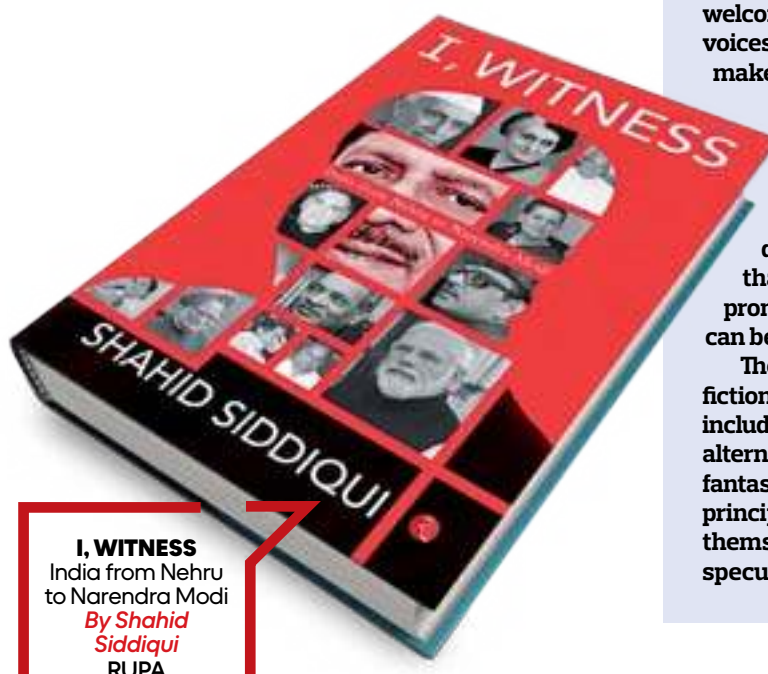
I, Witness is a racy read, full of anecdotes, gossip, events and perspectives, as Shahid Siddiqui, editor of Urdu weekly *Nai Duniya*, saw it. He is the quintessential Dilliwala, born in Ballimaran, old Delhi, in post-Partition India. As a six-year-old, he is taken to meet Jawaharlal Nehru by his father, referred to as Abba, a Deoband maulana who would become an influential editor and later be jailed during the 1975 Emergency. The grown-up Shahid Siddiqui would be both journalist and part-time politician, who would interview all Indian prime ministers from Indira Gandhi to Narendra Modi—and be expelled from the Samajwadi Party for speaking to the then Gujarat chief minister.

It's as if the author sat the reader down and shared the story of regimes past through anecdotes and impressions. Besides the principal characters of the past 50 years in Indian politics, tantriks, arms dealers, fixers and operators appear. On pages 104-106, for instance, he writes about Indira Gandhi becoming superstitious in the post-Emergency Janata Party years: a Swami Dhirendra Brahmachari was apparently performing tantric rituals for her, while a Maulana Ilyasi, who had occupied a mosque in Lutyens' Delhi, accompanied her to the tomb of Sufi saint Bakhtiyar Kaki in Mehrauli, where she performed rituals through the night. Ilyasi tells Siddiqui that one of the rituals involved slaying a *kaddu* (pumpkin) that symbolised slaying her opponents—who would soon collapse anyway.

Besides such hilarious anecdotes, the section describing the demolitions in Delhi during the Emergency are a reminder that bulldozers did not start moving yesterday. Again, preceding the demolition of the Babri mosque on December 6, 1992, the author is part of the Muslim worthies whom the Narasimha Rao regime is consulting. He believes the prime minister deliberately went incommunicado while the mosque fell—because he hoped to subsequently win Hindu support. Likewise, Siddiqui has a poor view of another prime minister—V.P. Singh—whom he believes implemented the Mandal Commission report as a tactic to survive and did not really want to stop the Ram Rath Yatra of Lal Krishna Advani.

There are suggestions that there were powerful forces behind the deaths of Sanjay Gandhi in a plane crash and Rajiv Gandhi in a suicide assassination. Fingers are pointed at foreign powers and arms dealers. How he got the famous interview with Narendra Modi is also there, but Siddiqui's descriptions of the Congress years is the really racy part. If there is one figure he truly loathes, it is former congressman Arun Nehru, whom he blames for overturning the Shah Bano judgment and opening the locks of the Babri mosque. ■

—Saba Naqvi



I, WITNESS
India from Nehru to Narendra Modi
By Shahid Siddiqui
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The charming USP of the Indian speculative fiction anthology *Between Worlds Vol. 1* is that half the writers are debut authors. SF author Gautam Bhatia edited the collection from open submissions. This welcome faith in fresh voices is also what makes the collection wobbly; some of the stories display the amateur's fumbling in the dark. Good then that a sequel is promised, where much can be improved.

The speculative fiction supragenre includes science fiction, alternate history, fantasy, et al. The first principles of reality themselves become speculative. So most of